Infants Can Form Attachments to More Than One Caregiver

Infants can organize relationship-specific attachment patterns with more than one caregiver; network size is not a dose, and a second caregiver is not automatically better.

ADE: MODERATE-OCCURRENCE; LOW-NETWORK-DOSE | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: ATTACHMENT, SOCIAL | REPLICATION: VERIFI

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Most children are raised by more than one caregiver and can form attachment bonds with more than one of them. Patterns toward mothers and fathers can be concordant or discordant. Dagan & Sagi-Schwartz (2018, 2021) argue that the scientifically useful object is a network configuration, not a single caregiver-child score treated as the child's relational world.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

The literature is primarily observational and longitudinal. Sensitivity is related to security across caregivers, but caregiver sensitivity is also shaped by child behavior, stress, resources, and history. Studies are few, often small, and historically mother-centric. This is not a randomized trial of "more adults."

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

There is no agreed dose-response for number of caregivers. Persistence is relationship-specific and revisable. Early classifications do not determine adult functioning on this card.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a for the occurrence claim. Samples often overrepresent Western, relatively stable two-parent households. Professional caregivers, kin, and fathers are unevenly measured.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean children need a single exclusive caregiver. Does not mean more caregivers are better. Does not mean group care, or a nanny, is interchangeable with a parent. Does not license using BEIP deprivation effect sizes (severe-institutional-deprivation.md) as a description of ordinary extrafamilial care.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Support stable access to responsive caregivers and reduce avoidable disruptions. Do not prescribe one universal family structure.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Dagan & Sagi-Schwartz (2021), New Directions for Child and Adolescent Development (PMID 34936190)
- Dagan & Sagi-Schwartz (2018), Child Development Perspectives